ties occurred because medical attention was not provided in time?

Again, according to this survey, 93 per cent believe that daughters and sons should have the same educational opportunities; why then is the dropout rate for females so high in middle school? Likewise, if 84 per cent of those interviewed are happy to have their daughters work outside their home, why then are women so few in the organised sector, almost negligible in ITIs and most often compelled to work at home even after they are educated?

the last word on all household decisions. In addition, 30 per cent of women have stated that daughters and wives should take their family's approval before spending the money they have independently earned. Shockingly, 14 per cent of women actually approve of husbands beating up their wives.

In some other areas, too, there is a restatement of established traditional and rather anachronistic attitudes. In spite of urbanisation and the churn in rural India, over two-thirds of those surveyed said women should not marry



FILTH CORRIDOR A garbage-choked sewage canal at Taimur Nagar slum, New Delhi

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

In many rural households, an educated daughter-in-law is prized not because she can be an independent earner but because she can help her male children with their school homework. On this matter, too, the survey points out, in loud asides, how wide the discrepancy is between what people say they do and what actually happens. According to the National Family Health Survey, 58 per cent of women are not even allowed to visit a health facility or market.

When it comes to gender issues, we find a fair amount of acceptance among women of attitudes that actually do not favour them. Surprisingly, 43 per cent of women believe that men should have

against their parents' wishes. Consistent with this, a high 61 per cent oppose inter-religious marriages and nearly as many do not believe in inter-caste marriages either. If there is one zone where tradition has dug its heels and nails deep in, it is gender parity.

In these areas, unlike those we encountered earlier where there were wide discrepancies between the correctness of responses by respondents and their actual behaviour, here we find a certain concordance. Fortunately, 70 per cent are open to accepting neighbours of another religion and about 60 per cent oppose religious discrimination in jobs. Even so, there is a significant proportion of people who still stand by religious prejudices and this number is large enough to be worrisome.

Besides, the fact that, on the whole, South India, led by Kerala, surges ahead when it comes to civic correctness, it is quite remarkable that there are many areas where there is very little difference between rural and urban attitudes. Eve-teasing is a menace in villages, too, and both rural and urban India said the right things on questions like ticketless travel, public littering, education of girls and electoral behaviour. This shows that education on these matters has seeped down to the villages, which is what makes the discrepancy between thought and action so blatant.

Likewise, even on matters of gender, the variations between male and female responses were not really as much as one thought they would be. There is a general acceptance of patriarchal attitudes across the country. Both men and women are, more or less, in accord when asked to respond on whether men should take the final decision on household issues. There is also a similarity in responses on the matter of marriage outside the community. Men and women alike are generally not in favour of such unions.

Two conclusions. The first and the most unexpected one, as mentioned earlier, is that an overwhelming number of people know what is correct civic behaviour but then don't follow what they know to be proper. Second, there is little disparity between rural and urban responses as well as between genders. One would have expected them to be much wider. Both points strengthen the view that enforcement and not moralising is the need of the day. The task ahead is to make people do what they say they do. ■

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